

Reading the Number Before the Round

Validating a Suburban Dog Park's Live Compliance Sign Against the Citations It Claims to Predict

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The problem

Council dog parks increasingly post a live off-leash compliance percentage from an overhead camera feed. Despite growing reliance on the readout for enforcement planning, little is known about whether it agrees with the citations rangers actually issue that week — or has quietly become the number rosters chase instead.

Research questions

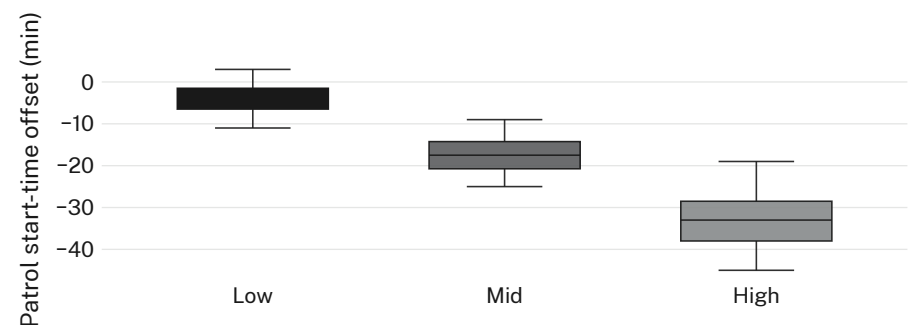
- Does the sign's weekly reading track leash-law citations issued in the same window?
- Has patrol timing begun responding to the sign's overnight number rather than phoned-in complaints?
- Does any sign-citation relationship hold across parks and shifts, or only where patrols already cluster?

Study design

- n = 46 site-weeks · 7 council dog parks · hourly camera reading, weekly citation counts
- cross-correlation of lagged sign reading against citations; patrol start-time regressed on prior night's reading
- lag window (0-7 days) and citation coding pre-registered; citations coded blind to sign data

Findings

Weekly citations tracked the sign's reading only weakly ($r = 0.31$, $n = 46$ site-weeks). Patrol start times moved with the reading far more tightly than with the phoned-in complaint line.



Median patrol start time across the high-reading tercile ran 34 minutes earlier than the low-reading tercile between March and August 2026 ($n = 46$ site-weeks, 7 parks) — a shift the complaint line alone does not predict.

Implications

Rangers appear to read the sign as a rostering cue, not a records check. Overnight readings above 80% pulled the next patrol forward regardless of complaint volume, suggesting the instrument has begun steering the enforcement it was installed to audit. The pattern held across all seven parks, including the two where citation coding stayed blind to sign data throughout the trial. Next: adding complaint-line volume as an independent third series, logged without sign access.

Selected references

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We thank the staff of the seven monitored dog parks. Camera counts de-identified; no dog counted twice within an hour.

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